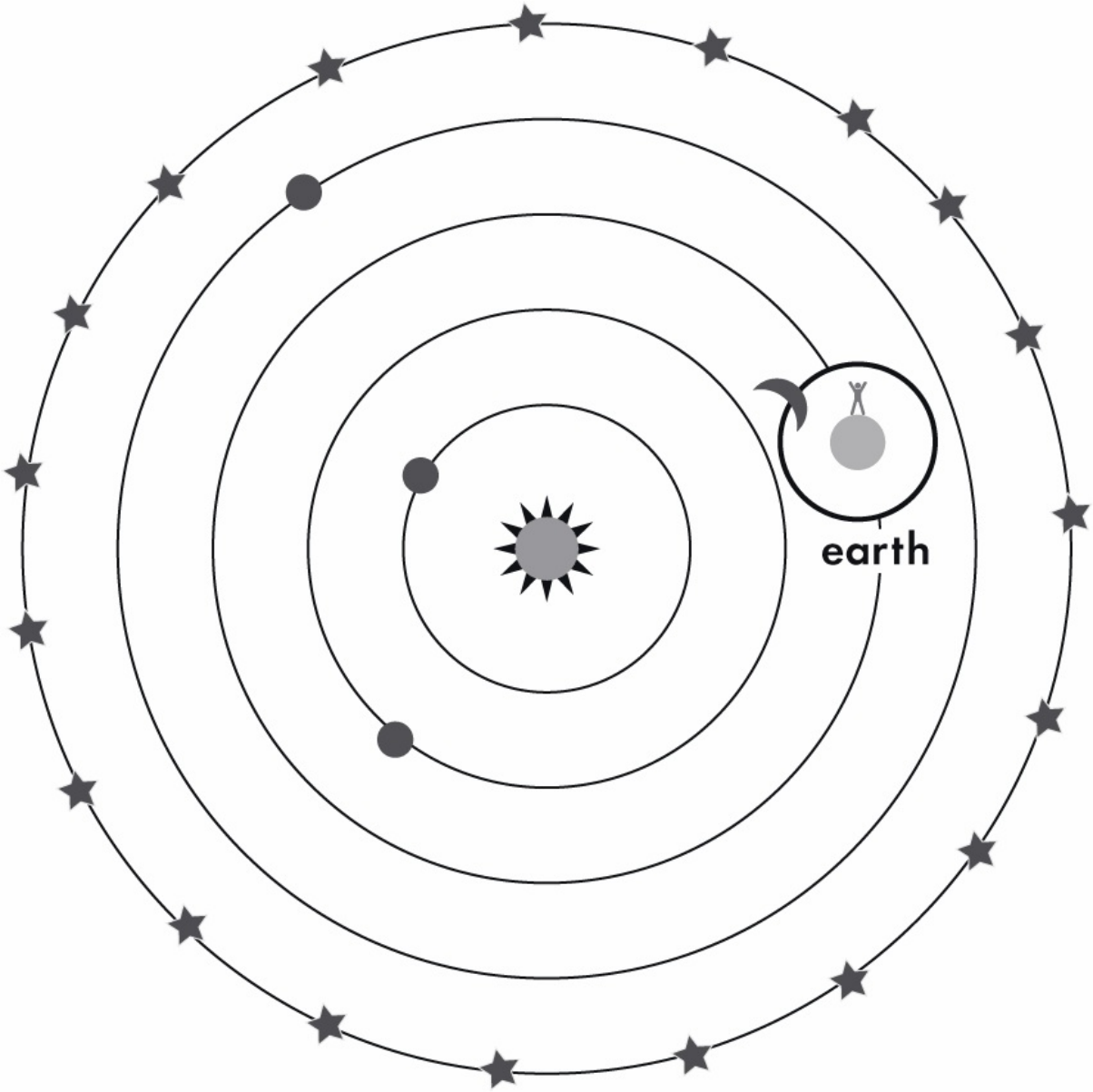


But there is in fact a key difference. Taking up an idea already considered in antiquity, Copernicus understood and showed that our Earth is not at the centre of the dance of the planets, but that the sun is there instead. Our planet becomes one amongst the others, turning at high speed upon its axis and around the sun.

The growth of our knowledge continued, and with improved instruments it was soon learnt that the solar system itself is only one amongst a vast number of others, and that the sun is no more than a star like others. An infinitesimal speck in a vast cloud of one hundred billion stars – the Galaxy: